Handoff 31: Data retention policy (master run S15, OPS-04)

Date: 2026-11-02 (America/Toronto)
Written by: Claude Code (implementer), in a separate git worktree
For: the human maintainer, and ChatGPT or Claude chat (reviewer) without repository access
Status: **in_review**: one pull request (#36), documentation only, not merged. Nothing is deleted by this PR, and nothing is decided by it.

> **How to use this file:** upload it with `docs/plan/retention.md` and `docs/plan/independent-learners.md`. The pull request diff is the source of truth (`build.md` section 14).

Starter prompt for the chat assistant

```
You are reviewing a proposed data retention table for Python Academy,
docs/plan/retention.md. Check that each "Today" cell is something code can
really be seen to do, that only decisions 18 and 19 are called decided, and that
the table misses no kind of data. It is not legal advice.
```

Run plan details

Field	Value
Stage	S15, OPS-04
Base	`main`, at `4b70a28`. No other PR needs to merge first
Part 2 boxes relied on	**None.** B-I6 is empty, so "24 months" appears only as a question

1. Step 0

`git fetch --all` and `gh pr list --state all`: #32 to #35 open. This PR is the fifth open, which is the cap, so the run stops after it. Worktree `../python-academy-retention`; the main folder was not switched.

2. Handoff record (build.md template)

Field	Value
Task	Write the retention table for every data kind, from decisions 18 and 19
Human goal	Before strangers can sign up, know what is kept, for how long, and which of those statements are true today
Non-goals	Any code or deletion job; the privacy notice (S11, blocked)
Data and compatibility	None
Deployment status	Not requested. Commits carry `[skip render]`

Files changed

`docs/plan/retention.md` (new), `docs/run-log.md`, this handoff and its PDF.

3. What was found

Finding	Where
Nothing but feedback and sessions is ever deleted. No `delete` in `main.py` or `admin.py`	Search of the code
Invitation rows keep an invited person's email for ever, even after expiry or use. That person may never have signed up	`db.py`, `main.py` lines 143 to 169
Every Google sign-in leaves a row with email and Google ID, even without enrolling. It is kept for ever, which matters more if SEC-10 shows sign-in is open	`independent-learners.md` section 5.1
Feedback's 50 days and 90 items are in the code	`feedback.py`
Backup and Render log periods are **not known** from the repository	Human task, OPS-02

These are gaps in a policy, not leaks: none is reachable by another user, and the plan's Part 4 already lists "no privacy notice, retention or deletion workflow". So no security stop was needed. The invitation and `pending` rows are newly named, and worth acting on before opening sign-ups.

4. Decisions and why

Decision	Options considered	Reason	Who decided
A "Today" column, separate from the policy	Only list the policy	A notice may only claim what is true. This shows the gap at a glance	Implementer

Decision	Options considered	Reason	Who decided
A new file, `docs/plan/retention.md`	A section in `independent-learners.md`	The master run asks for a table on its own, and other stages will link to it	Implementer (**assumption 1**)
30 days for invitations and `pending` accounts, as a suggestion	No number	A number can be answered yes or no. Marked as the implementer's suggestion	Implementer (**assumption 2**)
Unbuilt data kinds are listed anyway	Leave them out	S15 lists placement, and the others are planned. Each says "not built"	Implementer
Did not edit `backlog.md`	Update OPS-04	The docs sync does that, and #33 changes that file	Plan

5. Bugs found and how they were fixed

No code. No documentation bugs found beyond the gaps in section 3.

6. How it was tested

Check	Method	Result
Links and tables	The script from handoff 28	**3 local links and 23 table rows, 0 problems**
"Nothing else is deleted"	`grep 'delete('` in `backend/app/main.py` and `backend/app/admin.py`, and reading `feedback.py` and `sessions.py`	No match in the first two; deletes only in the last two
Every table covered	Compared the `__tablename__` list in `backend/app/db.py` with the table: `users`, `invitations`, `events`, `attempts`, `xp_awards`, `badge_awards`, `learner_goals`, `sessions`, `feedback`	All present

Suites: not run, as plan section 1.8 allows for a documentation stage; CI runs them. **Mocks:** none. **Deliberate-break controls:** none. **What this does not prove:** that the code behaves this way on the live site, or anything about Render's own retention.

7. Known limitations

- **Not legal advice.** The human task to read the PIPEDA material still stands.
- **Backup and log periods are unconfirmed.**
- **The run log conflicts** with #33, #34 and #35: keep the copy with the most rows.

8. Live checks for you

Read two settings in Render, and tell the next session what they say: how long database backups are kept, and how long request logs are kept. Nothing here changes them.

9. Questions for you

Section 3 of `retention.md` has five, each **recommended, not yet confirmed**. The two to answer first: delete never-enrolled accounts after 30 days, and delete invitations 30 days after expiry or use. *Recommended: yes to both.*

10. For the docs sync

Where	What
Backlog OPS-04	proposed → in_review (#36, handoff 31)
Stage table	"31. OPS-04 | Data retention policy | in_review (#36, handoff 31)"
Decision log	A short chapter from sections 3 and 4

11. Next concrete action

The run has stopped at the open-PR cap. Answer the questions, tick boxes in Part 2, merge what you accept, then run the same prompt again.

12. Removing the worktree safely

From the **main** folder, after this PR is merged:

```
cd /Users/DEV/Projects/python-academy
git -C ../python-academy-retention status --short   # expect nothing
git worktree remove ../python-academy-retention     # deletes only that folder; refuses if
anything is uncommitted
git worktree prune
git branch -d docs/retention                        # refuses if the branch is not merged
```

Don't delete the folder in the Finder or with `rm -rf`; Git would keep a stale record of it (`git worktree prune` fixes that).